

Access Barriers in Philippine K-12 Basic Education: Evidence, Scale, Impact, and Program Effectiveness (2023–2026)

1 Executive Summary

Access barriers in Philippine basic education are confirmed as real, large-scale, and deeply consequential across all four dimensions examined —learning resources, cost, geography, and disability/digital exclusion —collectively contributing to a 91% learning poverty rate and approximately 1.6 million out-of-school children aged 5–17 [1][2]. Critically, these barriers are not isolated; they compound one another, meaning a child in BARMM or Eastern Visayas who is poor, geographically remote, and living with a disability faces the cumulative weight of every dimension simultaneously.

The most striking finding is the systemic failure of program implementation despite substantial budget allocations. DepEd procured only 27 of 88 required textbook titles over nearly a decade, disbursing just 7.5% of ₱12.6 billion allocated for instructional materials (2018–2022) [3][4]. The Computerization Program delivered zero ICT packages from its FY 2023 current fund of approximately ₱11.4 billion [5], while only 48.8% of households have home internet access —dropping to 21.2% in Zamboanga Peninsula [6]. Meanwhile, an estimated 92% of the 5.1 million children with disabilities remain unserved by formal education, with only 648 SPED centers nationwide [7][8][9]. Hidden schooling costs push the poorest families out: BARMM reports 23.2% of children not attending school due to financial concerns, and indigenous children drop out at nearly three times the national rate [10][11].

Recent policy momentum —including the World Bank’s \$600 million PLUS-D project [12], the Last Mile and GIDA Schools Act [13], and EDCOM 2’s reform roadmap [14] —signals recognition of these gaps. However, the binding constraint is not policy design but procurement and delivery capacity. Until implementation systems are fundamentally reformed, even well-funded programs will continue to underperform, and the interconnected barriers documented here will persist for the country’s nearly 28 million learners.

2 Introduction: The State of Access in Philippine K-12 Education

The Philippine basic education system serves approximately 27.6 million learners across 60,272 schools [5], making it one of the largest education systems in Southeast Asia. Despite significant investments in expanding access —including the implementation of the K-12 curriculum and free public education —the system faces a profound learning crisis. The World Bank estimates that 91% of Filipino children at late primary age cannot read proficiently, a figure 56 percentage points worse than the East Asia and Pacific average [1]. Approximately 1.6 million children and adolescents aged 5–17 remain out of school, representing about 6% of the school-age population [2]. The primary completion rate reached only 73% in 2024, growing at just 40% the pace of peer lower-middle-income countries [15].

This report examines the structural barriers that perpetuate these outcomes across four dimensions: limited access to learning resources, hidden cost burdens on families, geographic isolation, and disability and digital exclusion. For each dimension, the analysis evaluates whether the barrier is **real** (supported by hard data), **big** (affecting large numbers of learners with regional variation), and **significant** (linked to measurable consequences such as dropouts and learning poverty). The report then maps government programs and policy responses against each barrier, identifying where interventions fall short and where reform momentum —including EDCOM 2’s landmark recommendations and the World Bank’s \$600 million PLUS-D project [12] —may begin to close persistent gaps.

3 Dimension 1: Limited Access to Learning Resources

The barrier is real. A decade of procurement failures left Philippine public schools critically short of textbooks and learning materials. According to EDCOM 2, the Department of Education procured only 27 of 88 required textbook titles between 2014 and 2023 [3]. The budget underutilization was staggering: of the ₱12.6 billion allocated for instructional materials from 2018 to 2022, only ₱4.4 billion (35.3%) was obligated, and a mere ₱951.9 million (7.5%) was actually disbursed [4]. Teachers reported not receiving textbooks on time, forcing students to share or rotate books while teachers produced alternative materials at their own expense [16]. The Philippines was identified as one of the countries with the highest mean index of shortage of learning materials in PISA 2018 [16].

The barrier is big. The scale of material deprivation touches nearly every public school classroom. In the 2019 round of TIMSS, 95% of participating Grade 4 students were found to be in schools where instruction was affected by shortages of learning materials in both Science and Mathematics [16]. Southeast Asian Primary Learning Metrics (SEA-PLM) results showed that at least one in five Grade 5 students shared textbooks with another student or more [16]. These shortages are not confined to remote areas —they are systemic, reflecting a procurement pipeline that failed to deliver materials to classrooms nationwide for nearly a decade.

The barrier is significant. The World Bank explicitly links the Philippines’ low learning outcomes to “subpar quantity and quality of learning materials” [12], contributing directly to the country’s 91% learning poverty rate [1]. Without adequate textbooks, teachers cannot deliver the curriculum effectively, and students —particularly those in the poorest households who cannot supplement with purchased materials —fall further behind. Procurement completion rose from 31% during 2014–2023 to 57% in 2024–2025 combined, and DepEd reported reaching 100% of 105 target titles in 2026 [17]. However, the legacy of a decade of shortages has already shaped the learning trajectories of an entire generation of Filipino students.

4 Dimension 2: Cost Barriers and Hidden Expenses

The barrier is real. While public education in the Philippines is officially free, families bear substantial out-of-pocket costs for school supplies, uniforms, food, transportation, and —increasingly —gadgets and internet connectivity [18]. For older students, expenses extend to laptops, tablets, and other digital devices [19]. These associated costs have been linked to higher dropout rates among disadvantaged populations [9], and the digital divide compounds the burden for the poorest households, who are least able to afford the devices required for modern blended learning modalities [20].

The barrier is big. The financial burden falls disproportionately on the most vulnerable. About 1.6 million children and adolescents are out of school, with adolescents aged 16–17 particularly at risk —12% of this age group is not attending school [2]. BARMM has the highest proportion of children not attending school due to financial concerns, at 23.2% [10]. The dropout rate for indigenous children is almost three times higher than the national average [11]. Income-based disparities in educational attainment are stark: 49% of individuals in the richest income decile pursue higher education, compared to only 17% of those in the poorest decile [9]. PSA data for SY 2024–2025 show secondary completion rates of just 75.6% for men and 84.1% for women, with school leaver rates of 2.8–4.5% at the secondary level [21].

The barrier is significant. Research analyzing PSA data found that the high cost of education was the primary root cause of school dropouts in 2008, while employment or job-seeking —itself a reflection of financial pressure —emerged as the top cause in 2013 [22]. These financial barriers create a vicious cycle: families who cannot afford the hidden costs of schooling pull children out, reducing their lifetime earning potential and perpetuating intergenerational poverty. The consequences are particularly severe in BARMM, where students experienced the most severe pandemic learning losses [11], and among indigenous communities where cultural and financial barriers compound each other.

5 Dimension 3: Geographic and Location Barriers

The barrier is real. Geographic isolation remains one of the most entrenched barriers to education in the Philippine archipelago. DepEd identified 9,225 underserved schools in Geographically Isolated, Disadvantaged, and Conflict-Affected Areas (GIDCAs) as of 2019, requiring an estimated ₱136 billion to address critical gaps in infrastructure, personnel, and learning resources [23]. The country faces a shortage of approximately 148,000 classrooms as of 2025 [9], and approximately 1,500 public schools still lack access to electricity as of October 2024 [24]. In remote areas such as Samar, learners previously had to walk up to three hours just to attend multigrade classes before road interventions under the Last Mile Schools initiative [23].

The barrier is big. In SY 2022–2023, 5,870 public schools offered multigrade classes —about 12% of all public schools —serving 277,908 learners with 28,364 teachers [25]. Region VIII (Eastern Visayas) had the largest concentration, with 1,276 multigrade schools representing 22% of the national total [25]. Among these multigrade schools, 15% are off-grid or lack electricity, and 51% have no internet access [25]. The infrastructure deficit is not merely an inconvenience; it fundamentally limits the quality of instruction that can be delivered and the learning modalities available to students.

Chart Explanation: This chart illustrates the gap between national averages and BARMM across three critical education access indicators. BARMM lags behind the national average in school attendance (78.1% vs. 81.4%) [10], household internet access (27.7% vs. 48.8%) [6], and upper secondary completion (53% vs. 73%) [15]. These gaps reflect the compounding effects of geographic isolation, poverty, and conflict on educational access.

The barrier is significant. Regional disparities in completion rates are dramatic. BARMM’s upper secondary completion rate stood at only 53% in 2022, compared to the national average of approximately 73%, though it has been improving at 1.7 percentage points per year [15]. Across regions, Zamboanga Peninsula (76.7%) and BARMM (78.1%) had the lowest school attendance rates, well below the national average of 81.4% [10]. Eastern Visayas, despite a relatively high attendance rate of 84.8% [10], hosts the largest concentration of multigrade schools, indicating that geographic access challenges persist even where enrollment figures appear adequate. President Marcos signed the Last Mile and GIDA Schools Act (RA 12321) into law in July 2026, institutionalizing

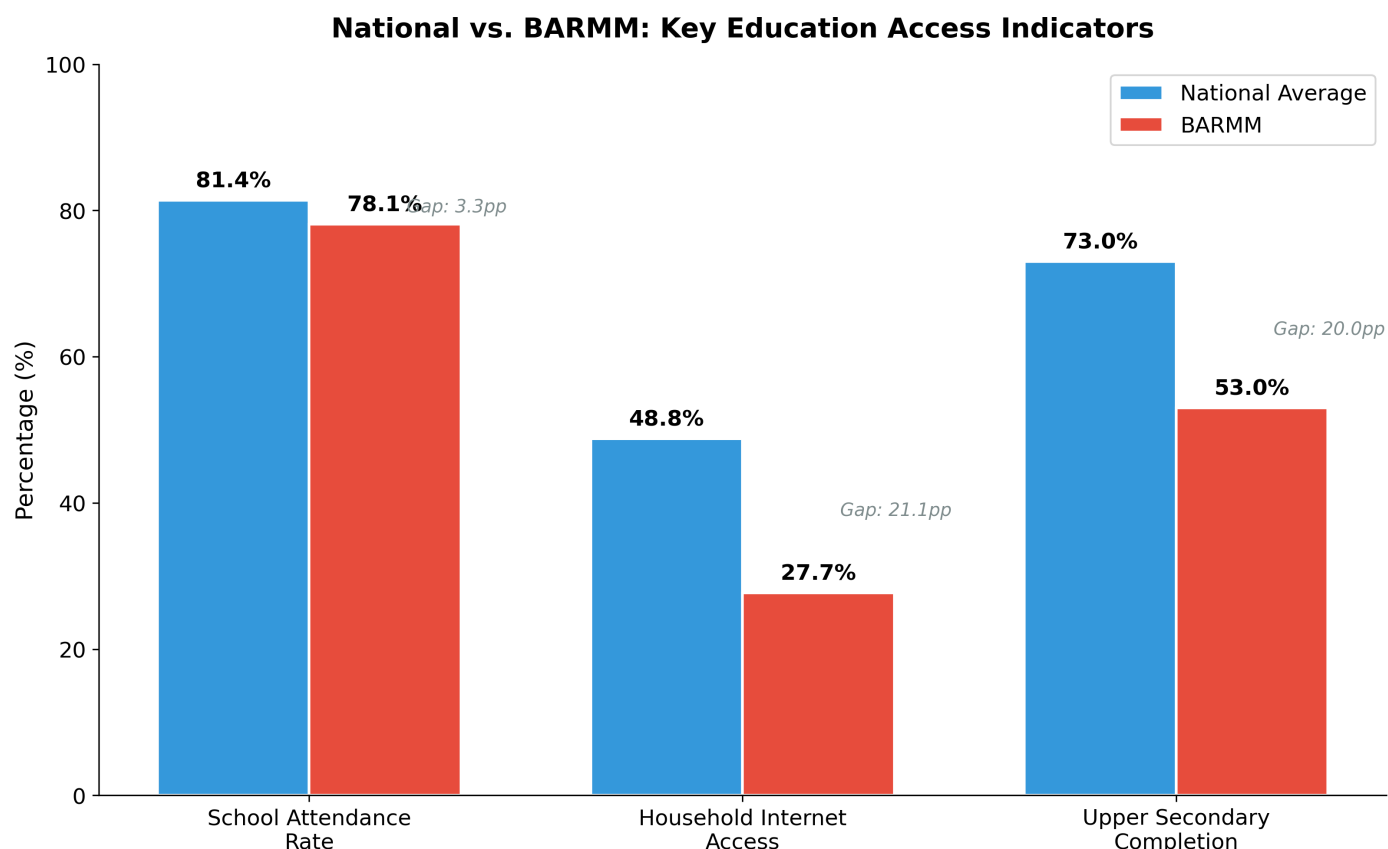


Figure 1: National vs. BARMM: Key Education Access Indicators

DepEd’ s LMS program and mandating multi-agency collaboration for remote schools [13], with an initial 131 classrooms planned for construction [26].

6 Dimension 4: Disability Inclusion and Digital Exclusion

The barrier is real. The gap between the estimated population of children with disabilities and those actually served by the education system is enormous. UNICEF and PhilHealth estimate that approximately 5.1 million Filipino children live with a disability [7], yet DepEd reports only 391,089 learners with disabilities enrolled in public schools for SY 2024–2025 [8]. This suggests that roughly 92% of children with disabilities may be unserved or unidentified by the formal education system. The infrastructure for inclusion is severely limited: DepEd recognizes only 648 SPED centers nationwide —471 at the elementary level and 177 at the secondary level [9]. Only one in five children with disabilities possesses a disability ID card, limiting their access to services [27], and there are only 96 developmental-behavioral pediatricians in the entire country to conduct assessments [9].

The barrier is big —and compounded by digital exclusion. According to the PSA’ s 2024 National ICT Household Survey, only 48.8% of Filipino households had internet access at home, meaning over half (51.2%) remain unconnected [6]. The digital divide is sharpest in the regions that already face the greatest educational challenges: BARMM had only 27.7% household internet access, and Zamboanga Peninsula just 21.2% [6]. A DepEd survey found that 2,138,630 learners do not have a laptop, desktop, gadget, TV, or radio [28]. Among individual internet users, cellphones remain the dominant device at 98.8%, while only 14.7% use laptops and 10.0% use desktops [29]. The 2024 FLEMMS found that about 21.8% of Filipinos aged 15–64 —approximately 16.17 million individuals —did not use the internet at all during the reference period [30].

The barrier is significant. Digital exclusion effectively creates a two-tier education system: students with devices and connectivity can access blended learning, digital resources, and supplementary materials, while those without are confined to whatever physical materials their school can provide —which, as documented above, are often inadequate. For children with disabilities, the barriers compound: limited SPED centers, scarce diagnostic professionals, and absent assistive technology mean that millions of children are effectively invisible to the education system. The consequences extend beyond schooling into lifelong economic exclusion.

7 Government Programs and Where They Fall Short

The Philippine government operates several major programs targeting access barriers, but implementation gaps significantly limit their effectiveness. The table below summarizes key programs and their FY 2023 performance:

Program	FY 2023 Budget	Beneficiaries/ Output	Achievement Rate	Key Gap
GASTPE-ESC	~₱12.5B	859,996 grantees	73% of target	Voucher value inadequacy; weak targeting of disadvantaged children [31]
GASTPE-SHS VP	~₱39.3B	1,228,257 grantees	108% of target	Ghost student allegations and governance challenges [5]
Last Mile Schools	₱1.5B	76 of 277 schools completed	27% of target	Procurement delays and geographic challenges [5]
Alternative Learning System	~₱4.3B	564,545 enrollees	88% of target	Reaches only ~15% of 5–6 million prospective learners [32]
DepEd Computerization	~₱11.4B	0 ICT packages (current fund)	0% of target	Severe procurement delays; zero delivery on FY2023 current funds [5]

Table: Government Program Performance Summary, FY 2023

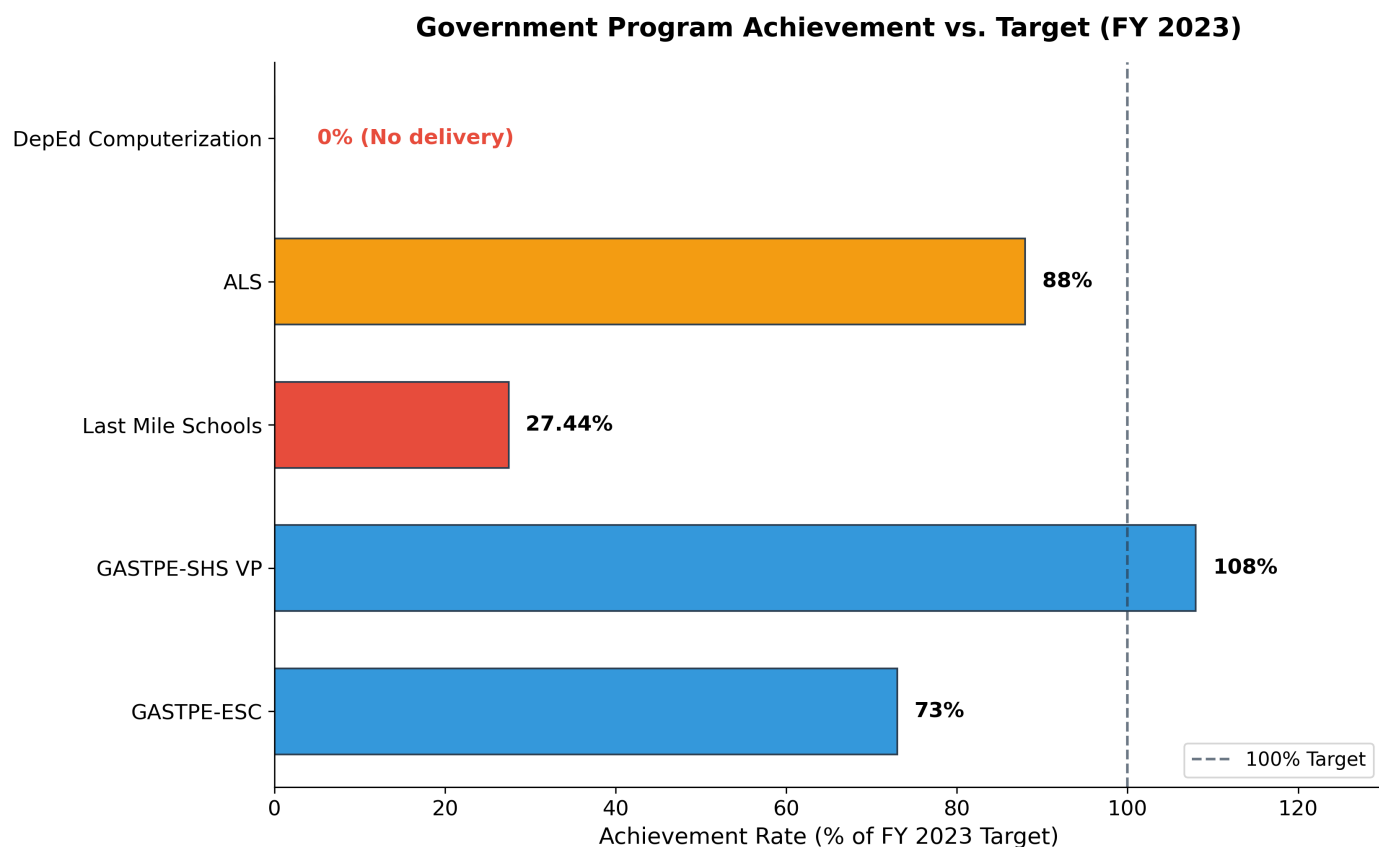


Figure 2: Government Program Achievement vs. Target (FY 2023)

Chart Explanation: This chart visualizes the stark variation in program delivery across DepEd's five major access-related programs. While GASTPE-SHS VP exceeded its target at 108% [5] and ALS reached 88% [32], the Last Mile

Schools program completed only 27% of planned schools [5], and the Computerization Program delivered zero ICT packages from its FY 2023 current fund allocation [5]. GASTPE-ESC reached 73% of its grantee target [31].

The GASTPE program, which collectively served approximately 2.1 million grantees, faces structural challenges. A PIDS study commissioned by EDCOM 2 concluded that while the logic of using private schools to supplement public capacity is reasonable and cost-effective, significant design, implementation, and governance challenges remain —particularly around subsidy adequacy and the targeting of disadvantaged children [31]. The Senate ratified an expanded GASTPE voucher bill in September 2026, creating a targeted K-12 voucher system prioritizing learners from overcrowded public schools and areas without nearby public schools [33].

The Alternative Learning System, designed to reach out-of-school youth and adults, attracts only approximately 15% of its 5–6 million prospective learners [32], leaving the vast majority of those who have already dropped out without a viable pathway back to education. The DepEd Computerization Program’s failure to deliver any ICT packages from its FY 2023 current fund —despite an allocation of approximately ₱11.4 billion —represents perhaps the most alarming implementation gap, given the critical importance of digital infrastructure for modern education delivery [5].

On the positive side, the World Bank approved \$600 million for the Project for Learning Upgrade Support and Decentralization (PLUS-D) in April 2026, aimed at improving foundational literacy and numeracy outcomes and expanding access to inclusive teaching-learning materials [12]. The Last Mile and GIDA Schools Act (RA 12321), signed in July 2026, institutionalizes support for remote schools [13], though its initial scope of 131 classrooms [26] is modest relative to the 9,225 underserved schools identified and the ₱136 billion estimated investment needed [23].

8 EDCOM 2 Findings and the Path Forward

The Second Congressional Commission on Education (EDCOM 2) released its final report, “Turning Point: A Decade of Necessary Reform,” in early 2026, diagnosing a systemic failure in Philippine education. The report highlights a central tension: while access has expanded, learning progression has stalled, leaving the country’s largest-ever youth cohort —approximately 29.9 million Filipinos aged 15–29 in 2024 —without the skills foundation needed to sustain economic growth [14]. UNICEF called the EDCOM 2 report a “critical guide” for reforms, emphasizing priority recommendations that include increased investments in early childhood nutrition (citing approximately 24% stunting among children under five), improved literacy outcomes by Grade 3, and reformed teacher workload and school staffing structures [34].

DepEd’s Quality Basic Education Development Plan (QBEDP) 2025–2035 identifies three strategic levers for delivery: decentralization, public-private partnerships, and digitalization [35]. These levers align with the barriers documented in this report —decentralization to address geographic isolation, PPPs to supplement public capacity through programs like GASTPE, and digitalization to bridge resource and connectivity gaps. However, the severe procurement delays evident in the Computerization Program and Last Mile Schools suggest that implementation capacity, rather than policy design, remains the binding constraint.

The evidence presented across all four dimensions confirms that access barriers in Philippine basic education are real, big, and significant. They are not isolated problems but interconnected challenges that compound each other: a child in BARMM who is poor, lives in a remote area, and has a disability faces the full weight of every barrier simultaneously. Closing these gaps will require not only sustained budget increases but fundamental reforms in procurement, program targeting, and institutional capacity —reforms that EDCOM 2 has outlined but that remain largely ahead of the country as of late 2026.

9 Data Gaps and Measurement Challenges

Despite the wealth of statistics cited in this report, significant data gaps persist. No comprehensive national-level data on library access rates in public schools was identified in available DepEd or EDCOM 2 publications. Disability-disaggregated education outcomes remain scarce, making it difficult to track whether the estimated 92% of unserved children with disabilities are being reached over time. Regional breakdowns of hidden schooling costs —transport, supplies, gadgets —are not systematically collected, limiting the ability to design targeted financial interventions. The PSA’s household surveys provide valuable snapshots of internet and device access, but these are not linked to individual learner records, making it difficult to assess the precise overlap between digital exclusion and learning outcomes. Strengthening data systems to capture these intersecting dimensions of disadvantage is itself a prerequisite for effective policy response.

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